Each of these directories is added to the load path only if it exists.

In addition, Rails will load a per-environment configuration file. This file lives in the `environments` directory and is where you place configuration options that vary depending on the environment.

This is done because Rails recognizes that your needs, as a developer, are very different when writing code, testing code, and running that code in production. When writing code, you want lots of logging, convenient reloading of changed source files, in-your-face notification of errors, and so on. In testing, you want a system that exists in isolation so you can have repeatable results. In production, your system should be tuned for performance, and users should be kept away from errors.

The switch that dictates the runtime environment is external to your application. This means that no application code needs to be changed as you move from development through testing to production. When starting a server with the `bin/rails server` command, we use the `-e` option:

```
depot> bin/rails server -e development
depot> bin/rails server -e test
depot> bin/rails server -e production
```

If you have special requirements, such as if you favor having a *staging* environment, you can create your own environments. You'll need to add a new section to the database configuration file and a new file to the `config/environments` directory.

What you put into these configuration files is entirely up to you. You can find a list of configuration parameters you can set in the Configuring Rails Applications guide.[97]